A Girl Named Zippy

By Haven Kimmel

Zippy: *(Looking through binoculars at a woman named Edythe who lives across the street.)* My sister says she eats a stew made out of puppies.

Julie: Nuh uhn. *(spoken as if she wants to hear more)*

Zippy: Melinda says she takes the puppies when they're at their cutest, when they've got all that extra skin, and just tosses them in a pot of boiling water with some carrots, and that's her dinner.

INTRODUCTION

A kindergarten report card summed up the young Haven Kimmel as someone who "is disruptive in class. Colors outside of the lines. Talks out of turn." Instead of registering disappointment, her parents promptly congratulated her for this achievement. Encouraged, their daughter developed a distinctive personality through her own characteristically sprightly rules. Affectionately nicknamed after a roller-skating chimpanzee, Zippy Jarvis finds her whimsical name only the beginning of her unique adventures in tiny Mooreland, Indiana.

A Girl Named Zippy - Growing Up Small in Mooreland, Indiana. By Haven Kimmel.

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Zippy: *(spoken directly to the audience)* When I told my mom about the puppy stew she just said pshaw. I asked her wasn't it a fact that Edythe was all the time trying to kill my best cat, PeeDink, and she said Edythe just didn't like cats in her yard, and that PeeDink always got away safely. I asked her wasn't it true that at our last church picnic Edythe had brought cookies that appeared to be covered in snot?

Mom: Now you're just being ridiculous. *(trying to shoo her outside)*

Zippy: What were they made of, then?

Mom: Well. I'm sure I can't say. But only because I didn't taste them.

Zippy: Ah ha! You didn't taste them because they came out of Ede's nose, that's why!

Mom: *(snorting)* You're shameless. We should feel nothing but pity for that old woman.

Zippy: *(Pushed out the door by her mom. Spoken directly to the audience)* I was convinced Edythe ate puppy stew in order to give her strength to put spells on people. I thought this because my sister had also mentioned, in passing, that if Edythe got me in a hard-core eye-lock she could draw me right into her house. When I pressed for the details of what Edythe would do to me once she had me, my sister Melinda became uncharacteristically silent. *(To Melinda)* Tell me! I have to know! I have to know how to protect myself!

Melinda: Well, sweetheart, *(gently trying to press down a clump of Zippy's gravity-defying hair)* you know she hates all of us, but especially you. There isn't really anything you can do.

Zippy: Why?! *(wailing)* Why does she hate me so much? I've never done anything to her!

Melinda: She hates you because she and Mom used to be best friends, and then you came and broke up their friendship by demanding so much attention. Also she just hates little kids. But especially babies. Especially you.

Zippy: *(sitting, defeated)* But didn't she know I was going to get born when Mom was pregnant for me? Couldn't they have just worked something out then?

Melinda: (looking off in to the distance, still patting the top of Zippy's head)

Zippy: What? Lindy. What.

Melinda: I don't think I should be the one to tell you.

Zippy: Aaaaaahhhhh! Tell me what?!

Melinda: Mom doesn't want you to know yet, but I think you're old enough. *(Pausing for dramatic effect)* You're adopted. Mom was never pregnant for you.

Zippy: *(speaking to the audience)* Oh. This explained so many things. I couldn't think of any right off-hand, but I knew my life was about to become tragically clearer to me. *(runs inside)* Mom! Mom! How could you not tell me I was adopted?! Don't you think

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I have a right to know? And who were my real parents anyway? *(trying to be mature, but spit flies)*

Mom: *(reading a book and not looking up)* Gypsies, honey.

Zippy: Gypsies? Really? *(sits down)*

Mom: Yes, I thought we managed a very wise trade.

Zippy: Gypsies? In Mooreland?

Mom: They were just passing through. We heard them long before they arrived, because their horses and their wagons are all covered with bells. It's quite lovely. And they were led into town by a pack of wolves, who, during the full moon, stand up and preach. *(Looks up from her book for a moment.)* They were such a sight.

Zippy: What did you trade for me?

Mom: *(Looking at her lovingly.)* A green velvet bag.

Zippy: A velvet bag?! Who wants a stupid bag?

Mom: Well, it was a very special bag. It had no bottom.

Zippy: Ha! Joke's on them! *(tipping over a little to laugh at the gypsies, then straightening back up as she realizes she's laughing at her own family.)*

Mom: Oh, it looked like it had a bottom. It looked just like a normal bag, except that you could just keep putting stuff in it. It was like the human heart, sweetie: there was no end to what it could hold.

Zippy: If you had such a great bag, then why did you trade it for me?

Mom: The gypsies were camped out down at the school playground, and one night your dad and I were drawn by the preaching wolves. And just before we left, we peeked inside one of the wagons, and there you were, lying on a sheepskin rug in a pool of lantern light. And we took one look at you and it was just like falling in love.

Zippy: Ugh *(makes a little throwing-up face)*

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Mom: *(Picking up a few pieces of popcorn, and looking back down at her book.)* Plus, you were born with a tail. *(Zippy looks at her mom and is speechless, her mouth hanging open.)*

Mom: We had it removed so your pants would fit. Also we didn't want you to suffer in school.

Zippy: *(Jumps up and heads for the door)* Okay, thanks, that's good enough for me. I'm just going outside for a minute and . . .

(spoken directly to the audience) I stood on the front step for a moment, contemplating the news. Mom and Dad picked me up from the gypsies and Mom had to tend to me, plus there was all the trouble of having my tail removed, and Mom and Edythe couldn't talk as much anymore, and Edythe got really mad and jealous. And Edythe had gone on hating me just as much as the day I arrived in the caravan, and nothing would ever stop it, unless she could lure me into her house with the evil eye and squeeze my thumbs. The story snapped itself clear in my mind, like a mousetrap. The most important thing of all was, of course, that I was a gypsy.

I stepped off the front porch and headed for the drugstore for a lemon phosphate. I took my gypsy blood and my tail and walked right past Edythe's house instead of crossing the street like I always did, but just as I reached the edge of her yard, Edythe stepped out her front door whistling and I had to take off running for my life.

The drugstore was owned by a man named, no kidding, Doc Holiday. Many people found Doc Holiday's personality objectionable, but I appreciated how one always knew where one stood with him, which was too close and making too much noise. He

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never even looked at people as he shouted at them. Asking Doc for advice was a mistake. I was once in the drugstore when a woman asked if Bag Balm was good for diaper rash.

Doc: I don't know! What are you asking me for?! *(bellowing, looking north)*

Zippy: Doc was not in the business in meddling in other people's affairs. He didn't step into fights or defend small children from bullies. The bottom line for me was that I wasn't safe in his establishment, particularly not from Edythe. At the Marathon station, all the mechanics were on full alert when I was there, and would tell me exactly where Edythe was if they saw her approaching, and Big Dave had even figured out a way for me to climb into a little filthy tool closet if it looked like she was actually coming into the station.

But Doc Holiday was a man of no sympathy. Once when Edythe was chasing me I had blindly run behind the counter, and he instantly picked me up by the back of my shirt and plopped me right back in harm's way.

To be perfectly candid, Doc and I had a history.

My third-grade teacher had been, in my opinion, the meanest woman in the history of the Mooreland Elementary School, and a bad teacher besides. One day in the spring a tornado came, and our classroom was on the second floor, and when we could actually see the tornado in the distance we turned to our teacher to find out what to do and she was completely gone. I had to drag Julie under a desk, using my unexpected emergency strength, which I now know came from the gypsies.

So one afternoon in the summer after my third-grade year I was standing at the drugstore counter waiting Doc Holiday make my lemon phosphate, when in came my

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wretched, former teacher. I leaned across the counter and said, "Speaking of the Wicked Witch of the West, huh? There's no place like home, is there?"

(Spoken directly to the audience) For the first and only time in my life, Doc looked me in the eye.

Doc: She's my wife.

Zippy: *(Spoken directly to the audience)* He was very quiet, and so, in fact, was the whole planet. *(To Doc)* She is? *(whispering)*

Doc: What's her name? *(drilling holes into her head with his glance)*

Zippy: Mrs. Holiday. *(muttering, swallowing, can't look at him.) (spoken directly to the audience)* I wished for blindness.

Doc: *(Handing her the drink.)* That's 26 cents.

Zippy: *(Spoken directly to the audience.)* I knew that in an emergency I could never count on Doc, and so I tried to keep my guard up at all times, but sometimes I got sorely distracted, notably when the new Josie and the Pussycats comic came out, which it had on this particular afternoon.

I was standing in the corner behind the magazine rack, trying to read a comic I had no intention of purchasing. When my instincts kicked in and I finally looked up, Edythe was heading straight for me. She was staring right at me and grinning. *(stands frozen)* I began to pray to the baby Jesus that it would just be over quickly, that she would completely hypnotize me and drag me down to her terrible house and finish me off in whatever way she had planned, and that I would not feel any of it, like a gazelle being eaten alive by a hyena on *Wild Kingdom*.

Edythe leaned closer to my face. She got closer and closer, and when she was only about three inches from my nose she quickly and sharply clacked her false teeth

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together like a castanet, which in turn waggled her dreadful and fascinating whiskers and caused her seven chins to undulate in dray waves.

As my vision dimmed and my knees began to melt, I heard Doc Holiday say quite loudly to the ice cream freezer:

Doc: That's enough, Edythe.

Zippy: *(Spoken directly to the audience)* Still looking right at me, she straightened up and laughed out loud, clapping her hands in front of her like a child at a carnival. She marched out of the drugstore whistling "What a Friend We Have in Jesus."

I slid limply into a booth at the back of the store and put my head down, trying to catch my breath. Before I knew it, Doc Holiday was standing over me, offering me a lemon phosphate.

Doc: Talk about the Wicked Witch, huh? *(spoken grimly)*

Zippy: That woman is going to be the death of me. *(staring at her shoes)*

Doc: Well, what are you telling me about it for? *(bellowing)* That's 26 cents.

Zippy: I slipped the change out of my pocket and placed it gently in his dry, old hand.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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